> The GoI should not be blamed at all (for states facing an oxygen shortage). If anybody has to be blamed, it is states. I'll tell you why. As far as Maharashtra is concerned, we have been very honest with the figures. We were putting out figures of over 60,000 new positives every day, when the whole country was laughing at us. Many states of India were not even ready to admit how many cases they had. How does [the] Centre allocate to them? One of our neighbouring states had 6,000 cases when we had 60,000 cases. But I'm sure if they had tested properly, they would also have 60,000 cases… Now, how does [the] Centre allocate them equal amount of oxygen like us? So, when states have only 1,000 or 2,000 cases, their allocation will be very poor. If allocation is poor, people are going to suffer…[71]

While the Centre eventually did supply the 700 MT of oxygen demanded by Delhi after 2 May, it lay unused for many days since tankers sat idle as oxygen tankers in hospitals were full and thus were haphazardly diverted to other hospitals which they weren't meant for without even informing them. Allotment of re-fillers for hospitals was changed frequently, thus creating uncertainty and confusion due to which hospitals were unable to get their oxygen cylinders refilled in time, thus often resulting in oxygen shortage at these hospitals.[72] On some days, it was even returned to the suppliers.[73]

To understand why Delhi's demand was rather overestimated, it is essential to put the numbers in perspective by taking a close look at Mumbai's case study. When Mumbai had a similar caseload (approximately 90,000 active cases) as New Delhi in the month of April, it required only about 245 MT[74] of medical oxygen versus Delhi's constantly increasing demands of 700 MT, 900 MT and eventually 1,200 MT.[75] To get to the root of the problem, the Supreme Court set up a five-member subgroup which conducted an oxygen audit after the Centre ramped up its supply to meet the amount Delhi asked for. The audit revealed that the average stock of oxygen across hospitals in Delhi was about 1.4 times of the daily oxygen requirement, with some hospitals holding on to over four to five days of stock. This meant that Delhi was also holding on to the tankers carrying LMO for a longer period of time; some taking as long as 36–54 hours to empty, thus impacting the national supply chain. At a later date, on 23 June, the media leaked findings of the interim report by the Supreme Court-